

# melody MAKER

✱ Sanjay Sharma, 39

Project Making  
modern innovations  
in classical  
instruments

Can-do Icon Bishan  
Dass Sharma, his father,  
who taught him to listen to  
his customers, whatever  
their status. It is only  
through interaction  
that one can improve  
one's skills.

The length of  
the studio sitar is  
**40** inches  
while a typical  
sitar is 50 inches



On June 4, 2008, as Pandit Ravi Shankar played the last notes of Raga Pilu at the Barbican Centre in London, little did the mesmerised audience realise that the maestro was playing a smaller sitar than usual. Sitting on stage with him was the inventor of the "studio sitar", Sanjay Sharma, who had developed it in an anonymous little shop in Delhi. As

you enter Sharma's shop, there is no one to receive you at first but if you go a little further down, you will find him with eyes shut, tuning a sitar. With all sorts of tools around Sharma, you may mistake him for a carpenter but the fact is that he has put more than 25 years of his life into making instruments.

Rarely do connoisseurs realise that the art of making an instrument is as complex as the art of playing it. For how would Ustad Amjad Ali Khan or Ustad Zakir Hussain sound playing a sarod or tabla not made with the tonal quality to match their standard of music? Says Sharma, "An

artiste gets great pleasure when he is applauded for his performance but never realises that his achievement is, in part, the result of our contribution."

Sharma started learning the art when he was six years old, from his father, the legendary Bishan Dass Sharma. Dass used to bring Sharma to the shop on holidays when he would sit with technicians and learn how vegetables from the pumpkin family grown in Pandharpur, Maharashtra and Hooghly in West Bengal were turned into sitars, veenas and tanpuras. "My great grandfather Pandit Rikhi Ram started his establishment in Lahore in 1920 and, after Partition, his father came to Delhi and set up his own shop," says Sharma.

What has changed with the times is the demand from musicians to fine-tune the tone of the instruments by making innovations. Chitraveena exponent Ravi Kiran discussed improving his instrument's tone with Sharma and, lo and behold, a new veena took shape, the Navchitra Veena. "We have this constant urge to improve instruments and make them sound better," says Sharma, "And, in the process, we sometimes invent instruments that are not just museum pieces, but are actually played by musicians."

Sharma not only makes instruments but also customises models for musicians in India and abroad. Especially in demand are smaller instruments that are easier to carry around from one performance to another. Pandit Ravi Shankar has even acknowledged Sharma as his saviour for creating the studio sitar, which, with its shorter length and its own stand, makes it easier to play in his old age, yet allows him to recreate the music of his glory days. It is a functional art, at it's best.

by S. Sahaya R



RAVI S SAHANI

“Everyday is a new experience. For us, making each instrument is like making a baby.”

SANJAY SHARMA, Classical instrument maker